

Open Opportunities

Although Open Source is all about a free policy and collaboration, it doesn't mean that you can't have a lucrative career in the field

Jait Dixit
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Corporations and companies (small and large) have welcomed the Open Source philosophy with arms wide open! We should know, as our company has successfully transitioned quite a few processes to Open Source software. We've also been pushing FOSS (Free and Open Source Software) in India for over 11 years now. Why?

Open Source Software (OSS from now on) has radically changed the way people write code, or for that matter, changed the very code they write.

A survey carried out by Sonatype found that nearly 80 per cent of companies (which participated in the survey) used OSS in some way or another. This included companies from every conceivable sector – financial services, technology companies, software vendors, consulting firms, telecommunication firms, manufacturing firms, media and entertainment conglomerates, governments and even the military. The most interesting aspect of the survey was that it found that two-thirds of respondents had contributed to the community by giving code back, and almost half of all companies had open source policies in place – setting guidelines as to how employees should work with OSS.

Now it's obvious that OSS reduces costs in the long run for bigger companies, or even for start-ups, who may be on the tightest of budgets. It's natural that such companies give back to whom

they owe their success – the community. An excellent example here is Red Hat – perhaps the world's most successful enterprise Linux distro.

Show me the money!

There are two primary ways in which you can make money from Open Source. The first is when you have an Open Source project of your own, and you try and monetise it. The second is to get a job in an organisation using your own Open Source expertise.

One of the biggest mistakes people make is to assume that since OSS is free, companies cannot possibly make any

software sales at all prefer to give their code away. Not only do they generate a lot of goodwill with the community, they also save on the costs associated with hiring people to improve security and features of their products, as the community is only too happy to do just that. It's not at all uncommon to find patches and add-on features developed by external coders in the community to be added on to commercial offerings from big companies.

The success and quality of an open source project is driven by individual project governance and best practices. Most projects that are successful were started off as hobbies or something which the author(s) finds very helpful in their own development workflow. When managing or building open source projects, it helps not having a final vision right from the outset. It helps to focus instead on the nitty-gritties and quality of the code going in. The overall quality and success of an open source project is always driven by the effectiveness of the community surrounding the project. Poorly managed projects tend to die quickly.

Career opportunities

Not all of us can envision or start up an OSS project. In fact, 99 times out of 100 (if not more), any idea you have for a software is already being developed by someone else. You usually have two choices then, either join that project and become a significant contributing member, or take up one of the more popular OSS projects out there and become



Reach for a new horizon

money from starting an OSS project. We'll list out a few business models below to help bust that myth. Large companies (Yahoo, Facebook, Google, etc.), whose income doesn't really depend on